

Windows Registry

- **What it is:**

The **Registry** is like the **database or notebook of Windows** where all important system and software settings are stored.

- **Think of it as:**

A **giant library of settings** for Windows, hardware, and applications. Instead of each program keeping its own separate settings file, many use the registry.

How it is organized

The registry is arranged like **folders and files**:

- **Keys** → like folders (categories of settings)
- **Values** → like files (actual settings data)

Main Sections (Hives)

When you open the registry (with regedit), you'll see these big folders (called **hives**):

1. **HKEY_CLASSES_ROOT (HKCR)** – Info about file types (e.g., .txt opens with Notepad).
2. **HKEY_CURRENT_USER (HKCU)** – Settings only for the logged-in user (wallpaper, desktop icons).
3. **HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE (HKLM)** – Settings for the whole computer (drivers, services, installed software).
4. **HKEY_USERS (HKU)** – Settings for all user accounts on the computer.
5. **HKEY_CURRENT_CONFIG (HKCC)** – Hardware and display settings for the current session.

Examples of what is stored in Registry

- Default web browser
- Startup programs
- System policies (like disabling Task Manager)
- Hardware driver configurations
- Installed software info

Why be careful

- The Registry is **very powerful**.
- If you **delete or change** the wrong value, Windows or apps may stop working.
- That's why Microsoft warns: **"Editing the registry can cause serious problems if done incorrectly."**

How to open it

1. Press **Win + R**
2. Type regedit → Enter
3. Registry Editor will open

In short:

The Registry is the **heart of Windows settings**. It controls how Windows and apps behave.

Editing it can fix issues or customize Windows—but only if you know exactly what you're doing.